7.6 The Vrouw Maria wreck, Finland

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Location and surroundings

The wreck of the Vrouw Maria is located in the northern Baltic Sea in southwestern Finland in Finnish territorial waters approximately 90 km off the city of Turku (Fig.30). The archipelago around the wreck consists of countless islands and islets. The wreck is located at a depth of 41 m in a small dip surrounded by underwater shallows.

The owner of the sea area is the Finnish government land authority Metsähallitus. The wreck is situated in the Natura 2000 area of the Archipelago National Park. The area is also a restricted zone in the national park, in which entry, landing and scuba diving is prohibited all year round without a permit from Metsähallitus.

Since 2006, the wreck has been surrounded by a protection zone based on the Antiquities Act of 1963. The area is circular and has a diameter of 1,500 m. No vessels are allowed to anchor in the protected area and diving is prohibited unless linked to the sea rescue of a vessel in distress or engaged in research under the permission of the Finnish Heritage Agency. The Border Guard maintains surveillance of the area and the Finnish Heritage Agency monitors the wreck by visual check-ups.

Reasons for assessment

After the discovery of the wreck of the Vrouw Maria in 1999, a wide public discussion about the study, possible raising, museumization and ownership of the wreck rights started immediately. In 2007, the Finnish Heritage Agency published the Vrouw Maria Report. The aim of the report was to give information, background data and different options to cultural political decision-making and to the future of the wreck of the Vrouw Maria. The report was also a source of information to be used when studying the protection, safeguarding, research and display of underwater cultural heritage. An important part of the report was the evaluation of the cultural-historical significance of the Vrouw Maria.

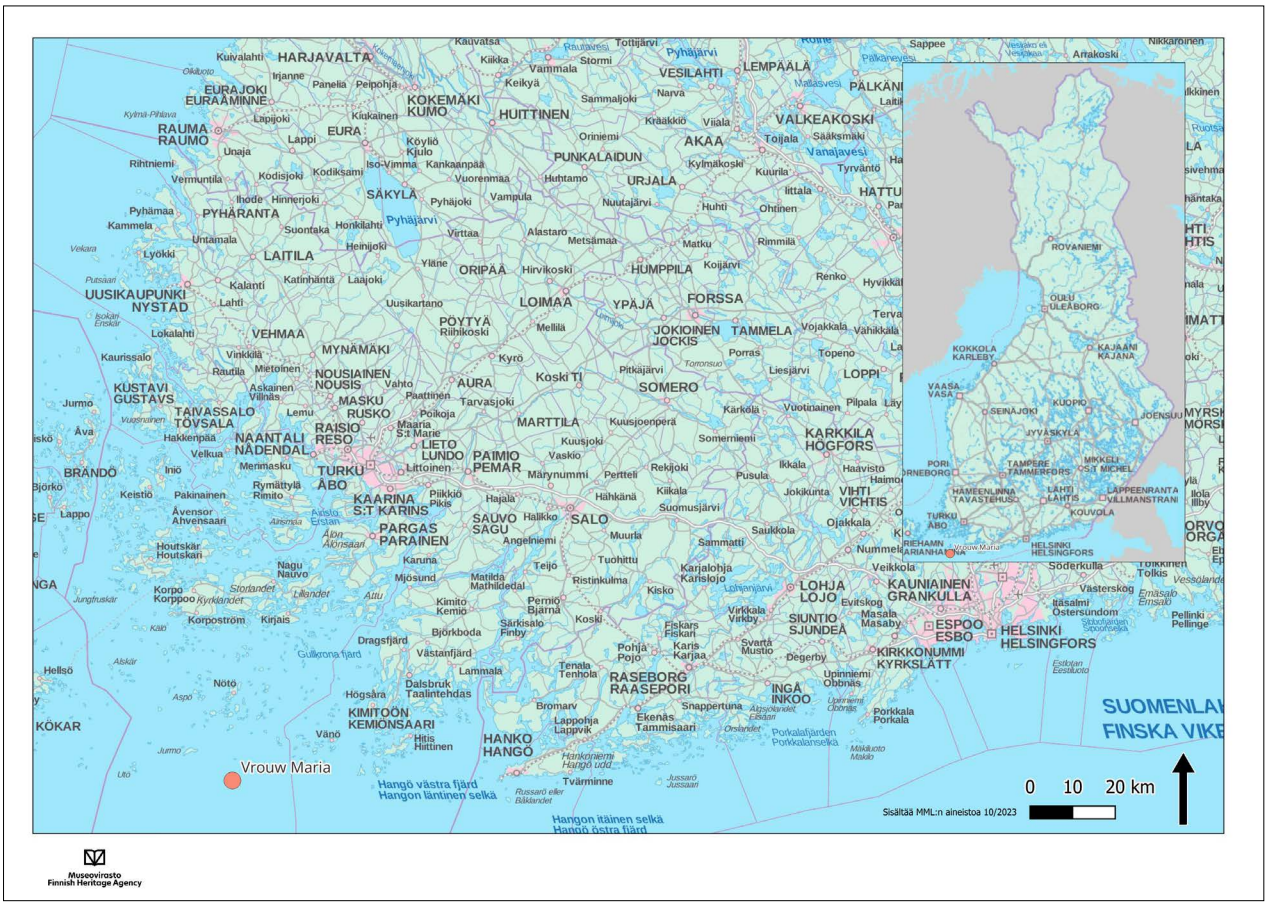

Figure 30: Location map. (Finnish Heritage Agency).